

1. At the beginning of the document, Neil...

- ☐ tells Georgina to stop texting.
- ☐ asks Georgina who she's texting.
- ☒ fails to ask Georgina his question.

2. Texting has become more and more popular...

- ☐ thanks to technological advances.
- ☒ due to the increase of cell phones.
- ☐ because people are too busy to call.

3. What question were British teenagers asked in the 2016 study?

- ☐ Why do you text so much instead of talking?
- ☐ When far away from someone, do you prefer to text or talk?
- ☒ Even if a person is next to you, would you rather text than talk?

4. What is texting also called?

⇒ 'talking with thumbs

5. With what phrase does Sophie Scott illustrate the importance of the intonation?

⇒ 'Oh shut up

6. The intonation of the voice doesn't affect the meaning of what we're saying.

- ☐ True
- ☒ False

7. What is intonation?

⇒ how a word is said

8. What can be misunderstood when reading rather than hearing a phrase?

⇒ The speaker intention

9. What other information about the speaker can we miss when we read a text?

- ⇒ age
- ⇒ region
- ⇒ gender

10. Having so many ways to communicate...

- ☐ allows us not to answer if we're getting annoyed.
- ☐ makes it easier for us to prioritize the person we should answer.
- ☒ leads to prioritization, thus disappointment of one of the speakers.

11. When Georgina talks about a minefield, she refers to...

- ☐ a conversation that never ends.
- ☐ an area planted with explosive mines.
- ☒ a situation that is complicated and dangerous.

12. In the end, how many teenagers said they'd prefer to text someone, even if they were in the same room?

⇒ 49% _____

Why do we choose to text instead of talk?

6 Minute English, BBC Learning English, 4min55s

<https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish/english/features/6-minute-english/ep-201203>

Neil: Hello. This is 6 Minute English from BBC Learning English. I'm Neil.

Georgina: And I'm Georgina.

Neil: Can I ask you something, Georgina...?

Georgina: Mm-mm-hmm.

Neil: Georgina? I said, I want to ask you something... are you listening to me?!

Georgina: Mm-hmm, just a second, Neil, I'm texting a friend...

Neil: Ah, has this ever happened you? Someone too busy texting to talk. With the huge rise of mobile phones in recent decades, communicating by text has become more and more popular and scenes like this have become increasingly common.

Georgina: ...and send! There, all done! Now, what were you saying, Neil?

Neil: In this program, we'll be investigating why people often choose to text, instead of talk to the people in their lives. We'll be asking whether this popular form of communication is changing how we interact with each other.

Georgina: And, of course, we'll be learning some related vocabulary as well. Now, Neil, what did you want to ask me?

Neil: My quiz question, Georgina, which is this. Young people are often the biggest users of mobile phones, but in a 2016 study, what percentage of British teenagers said they would prefer to send a text rather than speak to someone, even if they were in the same room? Is it:

- a) 9 percent?,
- b) 49 percent?, or
- c) 99 percent?

Georgina: That sounds pretty shocking! I can't believe 99 percent of teenagers said that, so I'll guess b) 49 percent.

Neil: OK, Georgina. We'll find out later if that's right. In one way, the popularity of texting, sometimes called 'talking with thumbs', is understandable - people like to be in control of what they say.

Georgina: But this low-risk way of hiding behind a screen may come at a cost, as neuroscientist, Professor Sophie Scott, explained to Sandra Kanthal, for BBC World Service program, The Why Factor:

Sandra Kanthal: When we ‘talk with our thumbs’ by text or email or instant message, we’re often prioritizing speed over clarity and depth. But when we can’t hear the way someone is speaking it’s all too easy to misunderstand their intention.

Sophie Scott: So if I say a phrase like, ‘Oh shut up!’ - has a different meaning than, ‘Oh shut up!’ There’s an emotional thing there but also a strong kind of intonation: one’s sort of funny, one’s just aggressive. Written down it’s just aggressive – ‘Shut up!’ - and you can’t soften that. [...] We always speak with melody and intonation to our voice and we’ll change our meaning depending on that. You take that channel of information out of communication you lose another way that sense is being conveyed.

Neil: When reading a text instead of listening to someone speak, we miss out on the speaker’s intonation – that’s the way the voice rises and falls when speaking.

Georgina: Intonation, how a word is said, often changes the meaning of words and phrases - small groups of words people use to say something particular.

Neil: Reading a phrase like, ‘Oh shut up!’ in a text, instead of hearing it spoken aloud, makes it easy to misunderstand the speaker’s intention – their aim, or plan of what they want to do.

Georgina: And it’s not just the speaker’s intention that we miss. A whole range of extra information is conveyed through speech, from the speaker’s age and gender to the region they’re from.

Neil: Poet, Gary Turk, believes that we lose something uniquely human when we stop talking. And there are practical problems involved with texting too, as he explains to BBC World Service’s, The Why Factor:

Gary Turk: If you speak to someone in person and they don’t respond right away, that would be rude. But you might be speaking to someone in person and someone texts you... and it would be ruder for you then to stop that conversation and speak to the person over text... yet the person on the other side of the text is getting annoyed – you haven’t responded right way – it’s like we’re constantly now creating these situations using our phones that allow us to like tread on mines – no matter what you do, we’re going to disappoint people because we’re trying to communicate in so many different ways. Do you prioritize the person on the phone? Would you prioritize the person you’re speaking to? Who do you disappoint first? You’re going to disappoint somebody.

Georgina: So what should you do if a friend texts you when you’re already speaking to someone else in person – physically present, face to face?

Neil: You can’t communicate with both people at the same time, so whatever you do someone will get annoyed – become angry and upset.

Georgina: Gary thinks that despite its convenience, texting creates situations where we have to tread on mines, another way of saying that something is a minefield, meaning a situation full of hidden problems and dangers, where people need to take care.

Neil: Yes, it’s easy to get annoyed when someone ignores you to text their friend...

Georgina: Oh, you’re not still upset about that are you, Neil?

Neil: Ha, it's like those teenagers in my quiz question! Remember I asked you how many teenagers said they'd prefer to text someone, even if they were in the same room.

Georgina: I guessed it was b) 49 percent.

Neil: Which was... the correct answer! I'm glad you were listening, Georgina, and not texting!

Georgina: Ha ha!